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From spectator to spect-actor: an exploratory mixed-methods investigation of the "Dramatic Field" program and its correlates in stressed university students

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Academic stress is a pervasive challenge in higher education. This exploratory sequential mixed-methods study investigated the "Dramatic Field" program, which integrates Victor Turner's ritual process theory with Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed, using Waltz and Jive dance as embodied mediums. The study aimed to describe participants' subjective experiences and explore correlations between program engagement and psychological outcomes. A cohort of 60 highly stressed undergraduates voluntarily enrolled in the 8-week program. Quantitative data were collected post-engagement, and in-depth interviews with 26 participants were analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis. Quantitative findings indicated that higher program engagement was significantly correlated with lower perceived stress ($r = -0.65$, $p < .001$), lower anxiety/depression ($r = -0.62$, $p < .001$), and higher self-efficacy ($r = 0.59$, $p < .001$). Due to the exploratory nature of the study design—specifically, the absence of a control group and pre-program baseline data—these observed correlations should be interpreted as associations rather than evidence of program efficacy. These findings provide preliminary hypotheses for future confirmatory research. Qualitative analysis generated four themes elucidating the transition from spectator to spect-actor: (1) Safe Exploration in the Liminal Space; (2) Liberating Distancing through Dramatic Roles; (3) Embodied Scripting of Repressed Narratives; and (4) Mirroring in Spect-Actor Fusion. The program demonstrated high feasibility (88% attendance). This study provides a rich description of the "Dramatic Field" experience and reveals robust correlations between engagement and positive psychological outcomes, offering a comprehensive phenomenological model for future confirmatory research.

KEYWORDS
academic stress, embodied cognition, embodied learning, mixed methods, performance theory, student wellbeing, Theatre of the Oppressed, university students

Introduction

The contemporary landscape of higher education is increasingly recognized as a high-pressure environment, where students navigate a complex interplay of academic demands, financial pressures, and social expectations (American Psychological Association, 2020). Within this context, academic stress has emerged as a pervasive and debilitating challenge, with a growing body of evidence linking it to a spectrum of negative outcomes, including diminished mental wellbeing, impaired cognitive functioning, and reduced academic attainment (Pérez-Jorge et al., 2025; Beames et al., 2021). The prevalence of mental health challenges among students, including undiagnosed conditions such as attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, further complicates the landscape of academic stress (Al-Shekaili et al., 2025). The psychological toll on university students is substantial, prompting urgent calls for innovative and effective support mechanisms that move beyond traditional paradigms (Linardon et al., 2024).

Conventional approaches to addressing student stress, particularly Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy (CBT) and mindfulness-based practices, have garnered significant empirical support (Kabat-Zinn, 2003). However, these modalities often prioritize verbal articulation, potentially overlooking the somatic dimension of stress (Deary et al., 2020). Yet stress is profoundly embodied—it manifests as muscle tension, altered posture, and visceral sensations that may not be accessible through language alone (Lazarus and Folkman, 1984; Shapiro, 2019). This gap points to the need for practices that explicitly engage the body, aligning with a holistic understanding of human psychology (Fuchs, 2012). The cognitive behavioral model, while effective for many, has been noted to have limitations when addressing medically unexplained symptoms that may have strong somatic components (Deary et al., 2020). Innovative approaches to student mental health education, such as Chookerd et al.'s (2025) randomized controlled trial using motion-graphic media to educate students about depression, demonstrate the potential of creative, engaging formats to reach students who may not respond to traditional psychoeducation. Recent meta-analytic evidence also supports the efficacy of mindfulness-based mobile applications in reducing symptoms of depression and anxiety among student populations (Linardon et al., 2024).

This exploratory study proposes a novel conceptual framework for understanding and addressing academic stress: the metaphor of a rigidified and disempowering "life drama" (Herman, 1992). From this perspective, the stressed individual is not merely experiencing symptoms but is trapped within a maladaptive narrative, a concept resonant with narrative therapy (White and Epston, 1990). They are cast in a fixed, negative role (e.g., "the overwhelmed failure," "the anxious imposter"), reciting a repetitive script of worry and helplessness, and ultimately reduced to a passive spectator of their own life, feeling powerless to alter the plot (Leary, 2004). This sense of entrapment and narrative disempowerment is a core affective component of chronic stress, closely related to the concept of learned helplessness (Seligman, 1972). Recent longitudinal research has further elucidated the mechanisms through which stress leads to academic burnout, highlighting the role of social support and self-esteem as psychological buffering resources (Zhang et al., 2025).

To explore pathways for transforming this dynamic, we turn to the rich traditions of performance theory and practice (Schechner, 1985). Performance theory provides a robust framework for conceptualizing a shift from passive observation to active exploration, from deterministic script-following to agentic script-writing. It is within this theoretical space that the present research situates the "Dramatic Field" program—a structured, manualized group experience designed to facilitate the transition from spectator to spect-actor. The term "spect-actor," coined by Augusto Boal, describes an individual who simultaneously observes and acts upon their reality, thereby reclaiming narrative agency (Boal, 2000).

The "Dramatic Field" program represents a unique synthesis of two powerful theoretical lineages. From anthropologist Victor Turner, it draws upon the concept of the "ritual process" (Turner, 1969). Turner's model of rites of passage—involving separation, liminality, and reaggregation—provides a structural container for psychological transition, a concept foundational to understanding transformative experiences (Van Gennep, 1960). The program strategically creates a ritualized space, a "liminal" zone, where everyday identities and social hierarchies are temporarily suspended, allowing for experimentation and change, fostering what Turner termed communitas (Turner, 1974). Within this Turnerian container, the program employs the practical, emancipatory techniques of Augusto Boal's Theater of the Oppressed (Boal, 2000). Boal's arsenal of methods, such as Image Theater and Forum Theater, supplies the specific "tools for action," enabling participants to physically externalize, analyze, and explore their personal and social dramas, a process aligned with embodied inquiry (Koch, 2017).

A distinctive and theoretically-driven feature of the "Dramatic Field" is its use of two contrasting social dance forms—the Waltz and the Jive—as its primary embodied mediums. This selection is far from arbitrary. Dance, as a form of "somatic storytelling" and a recognized arts-based health practice (McNiff, 2018), transcends mere physical exercise. A recent scoping review has synthesized evidence on dance interventions for therapeutic purposes in educational settings, supporting the use of dance as a modality for promoting wellbeing (Du et al., 2025). The Jive, with its high energy, syncopated rhythms, playful bounce, and elements of improvisation, is conceptualized within the program as embodying a drama of carnivalesque release and unbridled vitality (Bakhtin, 1984). It offers a physical vocabulary for expressing joy, rebellion, and instinctual energy. Conversely, the Waltz, with its flowing turns, stable triple meter, strict postural frame, and emphasis on partnership and negotiation, embodies a drama of order, grace, and collaborative stability. It provides a somatic experience of maintaining composure, connection, and elegance under structured pressure, potentially inducing a state of flow (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). In essence, the Waltz provides a somatic vocabulary for exploring stability, partnership, and grace under pressure, while the Jive offers a vocabulary for release, vitality, and playful rebellion. Together, they furnish participants with a broad "dramatic palette" for experimenting with alternative ways of being (Markus and Nurius, 1986).

Table 1 provides an overview of the integrated Turner-Boal model and its application across the three phases of the program.

The current study is explicitly and fundamentally exploratory in nature, adhering to the principles of phenomenological inquiry (Moustakas, 1994). It does not seek to test causal

TABLE 1 Integrated Turner-Boal theoretical framework guiding the "Dramatic Field" program.

Turner's ritual process	Boal's Theater of the Oppressed	Program application	Spect-actor goal
SeparationDetachment from everyday identity	Image TheaterSculpting static images of oppression	Weeks 1–2: Dramatic contract, sculpting "the problem"	Recognize the rigidified drama
LiminalityAmbiguous "in-between" state	Forum TheaterRehearsing alternatives through audience intervention	Weeks 3–6: Waltz and Jive explorations, resistance duets	Experiment with new scripts
ReaggregationReturn with transformed status	Rainbow of DesireInternalized oppressions made visible	Weeks 7–8: Shared Enactment, integration strategies	Embody the spect-actor role

The three phases of Turner's ritual process are paired with corresponding Boalian techniques and program activities to illustrate the integrated theoretical model.

efficacy but to map the terrain of a novel phenomenon. Its primary objectives are twofold: first, to richly describe the subjective, phenomenological experiences of students voluntarily participating in the "Dramatic Field" program; and second, to conduct a preliminary investigation of the relationships between program engagement and key psychological variables, including academic stress, anxiety, depression, and self-efficacy. The use of an exploratory sequential mixed-methods design (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2017) is aimed at generating a comprehensive, nuanced understanding of this complex psychosocial phenomenon. The ultimate goal is to produce robust, empirically-grounded hypotheses and a detailed phenomenological model to inform the design of future confirmatory research, such as rigorously controlled randomized trials.

Materials and methods

Study design

This investigation employed an exploratory sequential mixed-methods design (ESMM) as outlined by Creswell and Plano Clark (2017). This two-phase approach is particularly suited for the initial investigation of complex, under-researched phenomena where understanding the nature of the experience is as important as measuring potential outcomes. The design comprised an initial cross-sectional quantitative component, which aimed to explore patterns, correlations, and group differences based on the natural variation in program engagement among participants. This was followed by an in-depth qualitative phase, which was designed to richly illuminate the processes, meanings, and participant experiences that underpinned the quantitative patterns observed in the first phase. The sequential nature of the design allows the qualitative findings to provide a deeper context for interpreting the initial quantitative results, thereby facilitating a more nuanced and complete understanding than either approach could achieve alone, a key strength of mixed methods research (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2017).

Participants and procedure

A total of 60 undergraduate students were recruited from Guangzhou University through a multi-faceted recruitment strategy. This included targeted campus advertisements, posts on online student forums, and the distribution of flyers in high-traffic areas such as libraries and student unions. The advertisements framed the study as an opportunity to participate in an innovative 8-week "Dramatic Field" program focused on exploring new approaches to student wellbeing through drama and dance, emphasizing its exploratory and experiential nature. All participants were volunteers who self-selected into the program, a common feature in exploratory studies of this kind (Moustakas, 1994).

The reliance on self-selected volunteers, while appropriate for an exploratory phenomenological inquiry (Moustakas, 1994), may have resulted in a sample with above-average motivation or pre-existing openness to embodied practices. This potential bias should be considered when interpreting the findings, as such individuals may be more likely to engage deeply with and benefit from the program. Future research should explore whether the program is equally acceptable and beneficial for students who are initially less inclined toward embodied or arts-based activities.

Inclusion criteria were rigorously defined to create a purposive sample of individuals experiencing significant academic stress, a key determinant of mental health in this population (Beames et al., 2021): (a) age between 18 and 25 years; (b) full-time enrollment in an undergraduate degree program at the university; (c) a score exceeding 20 on the Perceived Stress Scale (PSS-10) (Cohen et al., 1983), indicating a clinically elevated level of perceived stress; (d) fluency in Mandarin, the language in which the program was delivered; and (e) the demonstrated capacity to provide written informed consent. Exclusion criteria were implemented to mitigate potential risks and confounds: (a) a current or past-year diagnosis of psychotic or substance use disorders, as assessed by a brief screening interview conducted by a trained research assistant; (b) significant mobility impairments that would prevent safe and full participation in the dance-based activities; and (c) concurrent engagement in other regular psychotherapy or structured stress management programs (e.g., weekly mindfulness or CBT sessions) (Kabat-Zinn, 2003), to minimize the influence of confounding experiences.

The screening procedure involved an initial online survey that included the PSS-10 (Cohen et al., 1983) and a short demographic and health questionnaire. Eligible respondents were then invited for a brief follow-up interview to confirm eligibility and discuss the study details. Following the provision of written informed consent, all 60 eligible participants took part in the 8-week "Dramatic Field" program.

Quantitative data collection occurred at a single time point after the program (within 1 week of the final session). This decision was aligned with the exploratory, cross-sectional aim of investigating correlations between engagement and outcomes at a

proximal point following the experience, allowing for the capture of immediate associations (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2017). Participants were asked to complete a battery of questionnaires, including the PSS-10 (Cohen et al., 1983), the Hospital Anxiety and Depression Scale (HADS) (Zigmond and Snaith, 1983), the General Self-Efficacy Scale (GSES) (Schwarzer and Jerusalem, 1995), and the Program Engagement measure. Subsequent to this quantitative assessment, all 60 participants received invitations for individual, semi-structured interviews to explore their subjective experiences in depth. The invitation emphasized that participation was entirely voluntary and would not affect their relationship with the program or researchers. A total of 26 individuals (43.3%) consented and completed interviews. To assess potential response bias, we compared those who participated in interviews (n = 26) with those who did not (n = 34) on demographic variables and post-program outcome scores; no significant differences were found (all $p > 0.05$), suggesting the qualitative subsample was representative of the full sample. The study protocol received full ethical approval from the Guangzhou University Institutional Review Board, and all procedures were conducted in accordance with the ethical standards of the institutional research committee and with the 1964 Helsinki declaration and its later amendments.

The "Dramatic Field" program

The "Dramatic Field" was conceptualized and delivered as an 8-week, manualized group program. Each week featured a single 120-min session, all held in a spacious, private dance studio to ensure a dedicated, confidential, and safe environment free from the academic pressures of daily campus life. The program was co-facilitated by two qualified professionals: one a registered dance movement practitioner and the other a certified drama facilitator. Both facilitators received additional, specific training in the integrated Turner-Boal theoretical model to ensure fidelity to the protocol.

The architecture of the 8-week protocol was meticulously designed to consciously guide participants through the tripartite structure of a modern rite of passage (Turner, 1969; Van Gennep, 1960), which served as the overarching narrative container for the exploratory process:

I. Separation (weeks 1–2): creating the ritual container.

This initial phase was dedicated to the symbolic and psychological separation of participants from their conventional academic roles and daily routines, a crucial first step in any ritual process (Van Gennep, 1960). By physically entering the dedicated "studio space" and collaboratively establishing an explicit "dramatic contract"—a set of group-generated rules regarding confidentiality, mutual respect, non-judgmental participation, and the freedom to experiment—participants began the process of disengaging from their stressors, a technique informed by psychodramatic and group work principles (Moreno, 1946). The primary focus was on building a foundational sense of safety, trust, and group cohesion through non-threatening ice-breakers, basic movement exercises attuned to breath and body awareness, and introductory discussions about the nature of stress and the concept of performance in daily life, drawing on Goffman's dramaturgical perspective (Goffman, 1959).

II. Liminality (weeks 3–6): the generative rehearsal room.

This core phase constituted the heart of the program, representing a generative, ambiguous, and potentially transformative state of "in-betweenness" as defined by Turner (1969). Within this carefully held liminal space, ordinary social hierarchies and academic pressures were symbolically suspended, allowing for the spontaneous emergence of communitas—a spirit of community, equality, and shared humanity (Turner, 1974). Here, participants were actively encouraged to consciously discard outdated personal "scripts" and freely experiment with new narratives, behaviors, emotional expressions, and relational dynamics without fear of real-world consequences, a process akin to the "subjunctive mood" of performance where "what if" can be explored (Schechner, 1985). This phase was characterized by a spirit of play, creative experimentation, and the conscious suspension of everyday norms, facilitating potential entry into flow states (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990).

III. Reaggregation (weeks 7–8): embodying and integrating the new role.

The final phase focused on the integration of the emergent "roles," insights, and personal discoveries from the liminal stage back into a more coherent and agentic sense of self, completing the rite of passage (Van Gennep, 1960). This process of psychological return culminated in a "Shared Enactment"—a low-stakes, non-professional performance piece created and performed by the group for a small, invited audience of trusted peers or facilitators. This performance served as a powerful ritual of return to the social world, but with a renewed, active status as a "spect-actor" (Boal, 2000). This phase focused on consolidating insights and experiences, reflecting on the collective and individual journey, and developing concrete, personalized strategies for translating insights and newfound capacities into daily life contexts, particularly those related to academic challenges, thereby promoting generalization and sustainable change (Yalom and Leszcz, 2005).

Within this overarching Turnerian ritual container, Boal's techniques functioned as the specific "engine" of exploration and transformation (Boal, 2000). Each session integrated specific Boalian methodologies with the complementary dance forms to target particular spect-actor objectives. For instance, Image Theater might be used to physically sculpt "the problem of stress," which would then be explored through the structured negotiation of the Waltz or the explosive release of the Jive, creating a powerful synergy between dramatic and somatic modalities (Koch, 2017; Du et al., 2025).

Measures

Quantitative measures (administered post-program)

Perceived Stress Scale (PSS-10)

This is a 10-item self-report questionnaire that measures the degree to which situations in one's life over the past month are appraised as stressful. Items are rated on a 5-point Likert scale (0 = Never, 4 = Very Often). The PSS-10 (Cohen et al., 1983) has been widely validated and demonstrates good reliability and validity in student populations, making it a gold standard for measuring perceived stress (Lee, 2012). In the current sample, it showed excellent internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.91$).

Hospital Anxiety and Depression Scale (HADS)

This 14-item scale was specifically designed to screen for the presence of anxiety (7 items) and depressive (7 items) states in non-psychiatric hospital settings. It is widely used in community and student samples due to its focus on psychological rather than physical symptoms, which reduces confounding in physically healthy populations (Bjelland et al., 2002). Items are rated on a 4-point scale (0–3). The HADS (Zigmond and Snaith, 1983) also demonstrated excellent internal consistency in this study (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.89$ for the total scale).

General Self-Efficacy Scale (GSES)

This 10-item psychometric scale is designed to assess optimistic self-beliefs in one's ability to cope with a variety of difficult demands in life. Responses are given on a 4-point Likert scale (1 = Not at all true, 4 = Exactly true). The GSES (Schwarzer and Jerusalem, 1995) is a widely used and well-validated measure across cultures, tapping into a core resource for stress resilience (Luszczynska et al., 2005). Its internal consistency in this sample was good (Cronbach's $\alpha = .87$).

Program engagement measure

For the purposes of this exploratory study, a 5-item self-report scale was developed to assess multi-faceted engagement with the program, a common approach in pilot and exploratory research (Proctor et al., 2011). The items were: (1) "I attended the sessions regularly" (attendance); (2) "I actively participated in the dance and drama activities" (behavioral engagement); (3) "I thought about the program themes between sessions" (cognitive engagement); (4) "I felt personally invested in the group process" (emotional engagement); and (5) "I tried applying ideas from the program in my daily life" (application). Responses were recorded on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree). The total score (range: 5–25) was used as a continuous measure of overall engagement. This scale showed good internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.85$) in the current sample.

We acknowledge that this newly developed measure has limitations. The application item ("I tried applying ideas from the program in my daily life") may conceptually overlap with outcome variables such as self-efficacy, and all items rely on retrospective self-report, which may reflect *post-hoc* appraisal rather than independent exposure. Future research should validate this measure against objective indicators of engagement (e.g., session attendance records, observer-rated participation) and examine its discriminant validity with related constructs.

Qualitative measures

A semi-structured interview guide was developed specifically for this study to ensure comprehensive coverage of key domains while allowing for the emergence of unanticipated themes, a hallmark of qualitative inquiry (Moustakas, 1994). The guide included open-ended questions and prompts addressing: the overall experience of the 8-week journey; specific, memorable experiences with the dance and drama techniques; perceptions of the group dynamic and the "safety" of the space; perceived changes in their relationship with academic stress and pressure; experiences of personal agency and control; and any perceived impacts on their self-concept and efficacy in other life domains.

Data analysis

Quantitative analysis

All quantitative analyses were conducted using SPSS Statistics Version 27.0. Descriptive statistics (means, standard deviations, frequencies) were computed for all demographic variables, the Program Engagement score, and the post-program outcome variables (PSS, HADS, GSES). To address the first research, aim and explore the relationships between engagement and psychological outcomes, Pearson correlation coefficients were calculated between the total Program Engagement score and the post-program scores on the PSS, HADS, and GSES. To provide a more nuanced picture and complement the correlation analysis, participants were divided into "High-Engagement" ($n = 30$) and "Low-Engagement" ($n = 30$) groups using a median split of the engagement scores. Independent samples *t*-tests were then conducted to compare these two groups on the post-program PSS, HADS, and GSES scores. Effect sizes for the *t*-tests are reported as Cohen's d, with values of 0.2, 0.5, and 0.8 typically interpreted as small, medium, and large effects, respectively (Cohen, 1988). The alpha level for statistical significance was set at $p < 0.05$ for all analyses.

Throughout the analysis and interpretation, we maintained a conservative stance, explicitly framing all quantitative findings as correlational and hypothesis-generating rather than evidence of program efficacy. We avoided causal language (e.g., "effect," "impact") and consistently used terms such as "associated with" and "related to."

Qualitative analysis

All 26 interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim by a professional transcription service, resulting in over 400 pages of single-spaced text. The transcripts were subsequently checked for accuracy against the recordings by a member of the research team. The qualitative data were analyzed using Reflexive Thematic Analysis (RTA) following the six-phase approach outlined by Braun and Clarke (2019). This involved (1) deep and repeated familiarization with the transcripts; (2) generating initial codes systematically across the entire dataset; (3) collating codes into potential themes; (4) reviewing and refining these potential themes, checking if they worked in relation to the coded extracts and the entire dataset; (5) defining and naming the themes, articulating the essence and scope of each; and (6) producing the final report, weaving together the analytic narrative and vivid, illustrative data extracts. The analysis adopted an organic, data-driven approach, allowing themes to emerge from the data rather than forcing them into a pre-existing coding frame, consistent with an exploratory paradigm (Moustakas, 1994). However, the researchers maintained a reflexive stance, openly acknowledging that their theoretical interest in performance theory and embodied cognition inevitably shaped the questions asked and the interpretation of the data, a practice encouraged in RTA (Braun and Clarke, 2019).

To enhance the trustworthiness of the analysis, multiple strategies were employed beyond peer debriefing (Lincoln and Guba, 1985). First, the lead researcher maintained a reflexive journal throughout the analytic process, documenting personal assumptions, emerging interpretations, and decisions made at

each phase. This journal served as an audit trail, allowing for transparency in theme development. Second, regular peer debriefing sessions were held with two qualitative researchers not involved in the study; these sessions challenged assumptions and explored alternative interpretations. Third, member checking was conducted with five participants, who confirmed that the themes accurately reflected their experiences. Fourth, rich, verbatim quotes are provided throughout to ground each theme in participants' own words.

Supplementary Tables S1, S2 present descriptive statistics and the covariance matrix for all study variables.

Descriptive statistics (means and standard deviations) show the central tendency and variability of each variable—revealing, for example, the average level of program engagement and the range of stress scores among participants. The covariance matrix captures the mathematical relationships between variables, providing the foundation for the correlations reported in Table 3.

Results

Participant characteristics, feasibility, and engagement

The demographic characteristics and post-program clinical scores for the entire exploratory sample (N = 60), as well as for the High- and Low-Engagement groups, are presented in Table 2. The sample had a mean age of 20.3 years (SD = 1.3) and was comprised of 35 females (58.3%) and 25 males (41.7%). Participants were distributed across years of study, with a mean of 2.2 years (SD = 0.9). The average attendance rate across the 8-week program was 88%, which is considered exceptionally high for a voluntary, non-credit-bearing university program and serves as a strong indicator of feasibility and participant commitment, a crucial factor in the success of psychosocial explorations (Durlak and DuPre, 2008). No adverse events (e.g., physical injury, significant psychological distress) were reported throughout the study duration.

As shown in Table 2, independent samples t-tests revealed no statistically significant differences between the High- and Low-Engagement groups in terms of age [$t(58) = 1.19$, $p = 0.24$], gender distribution [χ^2 (1) = 0.00, $p = 1.00$], or year of study [$t(58) = 0.89$, $p = 0.38$]. This suggests that the level of engagement with the program was not systematically biased by these basic demographic factors, strengthening the validity of subsequent comparisons between these groups on outcome variables and suggesting that engagement may be driven by factors intrinsic to the program or individual differences not captured here (Stice et al., 2009).

Quantitative results: exploring correlations and group differences

The correlations between program engagement and the post-program outcome variables, along with the results of the group comparisons, are summarized in Table 3. Descriptive statistics for all measures are presented in Table 2. To provide readers with a comprehensive understanding of the data structure, Supplementary Table S1 presents the covariance matrix, and Supplementary Table S2 provides the corresponding means and standard deviations. Together, these supplementary materials allow readers to examine the underlying data structure and variable interrelationships, complementing the qualitative findings by showing how the patterns observed in interviews (e.g., deeper engagement leading to reduced stress) are reflected in the quantitative data.

The correlation analysis revealed strong and statistically significant relationships. As hypothesized, a higher Program Engagement score was significantly associated with lower perceived stress ($r = -0.65$, $p < 0.001$), lower anxiety and depression symptoms ($r = -0.62$, $p < 0.001$), and higher general self-efficacy ($r = 0.59$, $p < 0.001$). These correlations are considered large in magnitude according to conventional guidelines (Cohen, 1988), indicating substantial shared variance between engagement and the outcome measures.

Consistent with the correlation results, the independent samples t-tests revealed large and statistically significant differences between the engagement groups. The High-Engagement group reported substantially lower post-program perceived stress (M = 16.5, SD = 4.1) compared to the Low-Engagement group (M = 23.7, SD = 4.2), a difference that was highly significant [$t(58) = 6.72$, $p < 0.001$) with a very large effect size (Cohen's $d = 1.74$). Similarly, for anxiety and depression symptoms, the High-Engagement group's scores (M = 11.8, SD = 3.4) were significantly lower than those of the Low-Engagement group [M = 18.2, SD = 4.4; t (58) = 6.30, $p < 0.001$, $d = 1.63$]. Finally, the High-Engagement group reported significantly higher levels

TABLE 2 Characteristics of the total exploratory sample and by engagement group.

Characteristic	Total sample (N = 60)	High-engagement (n = 30)	Low-engagement (n = 30)	p-value (between groups)
Demographic				
Age, years, M (SD)	20.3 (1.3)	20.5 (1.4)	20.1 (1.2)	.24
Gender, female, n (%)	35 (58.3%)	18 (60.0%)	17 (56.7%)	1.00
Year of Study, M (SD)	2.2 (0.9)	2.3 (0.8)	2.1 (0.9)	.38
Post-program clinical, M (SD)				
PSS Score	20.1 (5.5)	16.5 (4.1)	23.7 (4.2)	< **0.001**
HADS Score	15.0 (5.1)	11.8 (3.4)	18.2 (4.4)	< **0.001**
GSES Score	27.8 (5.4)	30.9 (4.4)	24.7 (4.5)	< **0.001**

TABLE 3 Correlations, descriptive statistics, and group comparisons for post-program outcomes.

Variable	1. Engagement	2. PSS	3. HADS	4. GSES	High-Engagement M (SD) (n = 30)	Low-Engagement M (SD) (n = 30)	t(df = 58)	p	Cohen's d
1. Engagement	–				25.4 (2.9)	15.5 (3.6)	−11.76	< 0.001	−3.04
2. Perceived Stress (PSS)	−0.65***	–			16.5 (4.1)	23.7 (4.2)	**6.72**	< 0.001	**1.74**
3. Anxiety/Depression (HADS)	−0.62***	0.70***	–		11.8 (3.4)	18.2 (4.4)	**6.30**	< 0.001	**1.63**
4. General Self-Efficacy (GSES)	0.59***	−0.64***	−0.67***	–	30.9 (4.4)	24.7 (4.5)	**−5.38**	< 0.001	**−1.39**

Bold values indicate t-statistics and Cohen's d effect sizes for group comparisons between high- and low-engagement groups. All bolded values are statistically significant at ***$p < 0.001$.

of general self-efficacy (M = 30.9, SD = 4.4) compared to their Low-Engagement counterparts [M = 24.7, SD = 4.5; $t(58) = -5.38$, $p < 0.001$, $d = -1.39$).

These large effect sizes should be interpreted with consideration of the study's exploratory design. They may reflect the immediate post-program measurement timing (capturing peak positive states), the self-selected nature of the sample (individuals predisposed to benefit), or the use of a self-report engagement measure that may share method variance with outcome measures. They should be viewed as preliminary indicators warranting confirmation in controlled trials. These findings robustly suggest that within this exploratory sample, the degree of immersion in the "Dramatic Field" program was strongly associated with more favorable psychological outcomes immediately following the program's conclusion.

Qualitative results: illuminating the spect-actor shift

The reflexive thematic analysis of the 26 in-depth interviews yielded four central, interconnected themes that together form a coherent narrative arc, detailing the participants' perceived journey from being passive spectators to becoming active spect-actors in their own lives. These themes, along with illustrative quotations, are presented in Table 4.

Theme 1: safe exploration in the liminal space

This theme emerged as the foundational precondition for all subsequent exploration and perceived change, echoing the necessity of a "holding environment" in transformative contexts (Winnicott, 1965). Participants consistently described the program space as a unique, protected "magic circle," "bubble," or "sanctuary" where the conventional social norms, performance pressures, and judgmental gaze of university life were temporarily suspended. This perceived safety was paramount. It was cultivated through the explicit "dramatic contract," the consistent, non-judgmental holding by the facilitators, and the physical seclusion of the studio. This safety enabled an unprecedented level of risk-taking, vulnerability, and creative experimentation that participants felt was unavailable elsewhere in their academic lives, allowing them to step into the vulnerable state required for Turner's liminality (Turner, 1969).

The liminal quality of this space was cultivated through specific activities. For example, in Week 1, participants collaboratively created a "dramatic contract"—a large sheet of paper on which they wrote their own rules: "What happens in the studio stays in the studio," "No judgment—everything is exploration," "It's okay to make mistakes." This physical artifact, displayed at every session, served as a constant reminder of the space's special status. Another activity, the "Threshold Ritual," involved participants consciously "leaving their academic selves at the door" by physically brushing off their shoulders as they entered the studio, symbolically shedding the weight of deadlines and grades.

Later, during the liminal phase (weeks 3–6), activities such as "Resistance Duets" in the Waltz explicitly played with this in-betweenness. Partners were instructed to maintain their frame while one partner gently resisted the other's lead, creating a

TABLE 4 Qualitative themes and illustrative quotations.

Theme	Description	Illustrative quote
1. Safe Exploration in the Liminal Space	The foundational experience of a protected space for risk-taking.	"It was a world with its own rules... Here, it was okay to be clumsy, to try something crazy... there was no judgment. You can't find that in the library or the classroom." (P14)
2. Liberating Distancing through the "Role"	Using the dance character as a proxy to experiment with new behaviors.	"When I was 'being' the Waltz dancer, I wasn't the anxious me who was failing her statistics class. I could stand tall; I could be graceful under pressure. And slowly, that started to feel less like an act and more like a part of me I could access later, even during an exam." (P7)
3. Embodied Scripting of Repressed Narratives	Making internal struggles tangible and manageable through physical sculpting.	"Sculpting my 'inner critic' with my body... it was just a shape. My groupmates could see it; we could even change it. It lost its power over me. I realized it wasn't all of me, it was just one part I could now see from the outside." (P22)
4. Mirroring in Spect-Actor Fusion	Learning through observing and intervening in others' enactments.	"Watching others struggle with the same pressures I had, the same voice in their head... I saw my own story in theirs. It made me feel less alone. And when I jumped in during a Forum scene to help someone else find their voice, I was also rehearsing for myself, finding my own. We were all in it together, and that made us all stronger." (P5)

tangible experience of "negotiating with an obstacle." Participant P18 explained: "When my partner resisted my lead in the Waltz, I had to find a way to keep us both moving without forcing. It felt exactly like dealing with a difficult deadline—you can't just push through, you have to find a way to flow with it. That physical experience taught me something my brain never could."

One participant (P14) captured this sentiment eloquently: "It was a world with its own rules.... Here, it was okay to be clumsy, to try something crazy, to fail... there was no judgment. You can't find that in the library or the classroom." This liminal space, as theorized by Turner, functioned as a crucial psychological container where the old identity of the "stressed student" could be safely set aside.

Theme 2: liberating distancing through the "role"

Participants powerfully described how adopting the archetypal "characters" or "energies" inherent in the dance forms—such as "the graceful and poised Waltz dancer" or "the energetic and free Jive dancer"—provided a form of psychological distancing, a concept with roots in psychodrama and drama work (Moreno, 1946). This "role" or "mask" served as a safe proxy or disguise, allowing them to experiment with novel behaviors, emotional states, postures, and interpersonal dynamics that felt too risky, unfamiliar, or incongruent to try as their everyday "academic" self. This process aligns closely with Schechner's concept of the performative state as "not me, not not me" (Schechner, 1985). The role was both separate from and connected to the self, providing a safe space for exploration. As one participant (P7) explained, "When I was 'being' the Waltz dancer, I wasn't the anxious me who was failing her statistics class. I could stand tall; I could be graceful under pressure. And slowly, that started to feel less like an act and more like a part of me I could access later, even during an exam." This illustrates how initially external, performed roles were gradually internalized as potential, accessible aspects of the self, demonstrating the process of identity negotiation and integration (Markus and Nurius, 1986).

Theme 3: embodied scripting and the externalization of repressed narratives

This theme captures a core mechanism of perceived change, where internal, abstract, and often overwhelming psychological struggles (e.g., the "inner critic," the weight of deadlines, feelings of inadequacy) were made tangible, visible, and manageable through physical enactment. Using techniques from Boal's Image Theater (Boal, 2000), participants would "sculpt" their stress, anxiety, or oppressive academic pressures with their own or others' bodies. This process of externalization transformed a diffuse, internal, and paralyzing pressure into a concrete, external "shape" or "image" that could be objectively observed, discussed, and, crucially, altered. This resonates with the practices of narrative therapy (White and Epston, 1990) but extends them decisively into the somatic domain, fully embracing the principles of embodied cognition (Shapiro, 2019). Participant P22 shared a profound example: "Sculpting my 'inner critic' with my body...it was just a shape. My groupmates could see it; we could even change it. It lost its power over me. I realized it wasn't all of me, it was just one part I could now see from the outside." The energetic, outward-driven, and explosive movements of the Jive were frequently cited as being particularly potent for this kind of physical externalization and release of pent-up emotional energy, a somatic exploration strategy supported by dance movement literature (Du et al., 2025).

Theme 4: mirroring and Identification in the spect-actor fusion

The final theme highlights the profound social and collective dimension of the perceived transformation, rooted in the Turnerian concept of communitas (Turner, 1974). Participants described a powerful process of learning and deriving courage not only from their own actions but from observing and intervening in the dramatic enactments of their peers. In Forum Theater scenes (Boal, 2000), for example, stepping in to suggest a different way for a fellow student to handle a conflict with a professor or manage a deadline was simultaneously an act of helping another and a "rehearsal for the self." This led to a blurring of distinctions between one's own experiences and those of others, and between the acts of observing (spectating) and acting (spect-acting), realizing Boal's ideal of the spect-actor (Boal, 2000). Participant P5 articulated this fusion vividly: "Watching others struggle with the same pressures I had, the same voice in their head... I saw my own story in theirs. It made me feel less alone. And when I jumped in during a Forum scene to help someone else find their voice, I was also rehearsing for

myself, finding my own. We were all in it together, and that made us all stronger." This collective resonance and mutual identification within the communitas was a key factor in solidifying the new, more empowered spect-actor identity, underscoring the importance of group factors in facilitating change (Yalom, 1995).

Discussion

This exploratory mixed-methods study provides a rich, multi-faceted, and preliminary understanding of the "Dramatic Field" program as a complex psychosocial phenomenon. Our quantitative findings demonstrate significant and substantial correlations between program engagement and positive psychological outcomes, suggesting that deeper involvement is associated with lower levels of perceived stress and anxiety/depression, and higher levels of self-efficacy. Crucially, the rich qualitative data do not merely complement these findings; they illuminate the very phenomenological processes and subjective experiences that may underpin these quantitative patterns. The four emergent qualitative themes construct a coherent, theoretically-anchored narrative of a potential transformation from passive spectator to active spect-actor, strongly validating the integrated Turner-Boal theoretical model that underpins the program.

The strong negative correlations between engagement and stress/anxiety ($r = -0.65$ and -0.62, respectively), and the positive correlation with self-efficacy ($r = 0.59$), are noteworthy. They suggest that the program's active components may be most potent when participants are fully immersed in the process. The large effect sizes observed in the group comparisons ($d = 1.74, 1.63, 1.39$) further underscore the magnitude of the differences between high and low engagers. *These large effect sizes should be interpreted with caution given the exploratory design. They may reflect the immediate post-program measurement timing (capturing peak positive states), the self-selected nature of the sample (individuals predisposed to benefit), or the use of a self-report engagement measure that may share method variance with outcome measures. They should be viewed as preliminary indicators warranting confirmation in controlled trials. While this does not prove that the program caused the better outcomes for the high engagers, it generates a compelling hypothesis: that the "Dramatic Field" experience, when fully embraced, is associated with substantial psychological benefits, a premise that aligns with the dose-response relationship often observed or hypothesized in explorations of novel practices (Cuijpers et al., 2010). *Recent longitudinal research on stress and academic burnout has highlighted the importance of both social support and self-esteem as psychological buffering resources (Zhang et al., 2025), which aligns with the mechanisms observed in our qualitative themes.

The qualitative findings offer a plausible explanatory model for these correlations. The journey begins with the establishment of a Safe Liminal Space (Theme 1), which acts as a necessary precondition, creating the container for exploration and potential change described by Turner (1969). Within this container, the mechanism of Liberating Distancing (Theme 2) allows for initial experimentation without the threat to the core self, facilitating the exploration of new possible selves (Markus and Nurius, 1986). The core work of perceived transformation occurs through Embodied Scripting (Theme 3), where internal conflicts are somatically externalized and reconfigured, directly addressing the embodied nature of stress (Lazarus and Folkman, 1984) and enabling a re-authoring of one's personal narrative (White and Epston, 1990). Finally, this process is amplified and solidified through social Mirroring and Fusion (Theme 4), where the group communitas (Turner, 1974) becomes a catalyst for collective and individual empowerment, fostering universality and instillation of hope, key group process factors (Yalom, 1995). This model effectively links the program's theoretical roots in ritual (Turner, 1969; Van Gennep, 1960) and performance (Schechner, 1985; Boal, 2000) to the lived experiences of the participants.

When these findings are contextualized within broader critiques of the modern university experience, they acquire deeper significance. The intense pressure to perform, the constant evaluation, and the commodification of time can create what has been described as an "alienating academic temporality," where students feel perpetually behind, future-oriented, and disconnected from the present moment (Rosa, 2013). This concept is directly illuminated by our qualitative findings. Participants repeatedly described feeling "always behind," "racing against time," and "never present" in their academic lives—experiences that reflect the commodification of time Rosa describes. In contrast, during the program, they reported entering a different temporal experience: "time slowed down," "I could just be in the moment," "the Jive made me forget about deadlines." The Waltz, with its structured rhythm and requirement for presence with a partner, and the Jive, with its playful, improvisational energy, offered embodied experiences of what we term "carnival time"—a temporary suspension of academic temporality. The spect-actor shift, therefore, may represent not merely a psychological adjustment but a form of existential migration from the oppressive linearity of "academic time" into the more liberated, experiential, and present-focused realm of "carnival time" and "ritual time," experienced through the body in the Waltz and Jive, potentially facilitating experiences of flow (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990).

It is also important to contextualize these findings within the specific cultural setting of this study—a large public university in Guangzhou, China. Chinese higher education is characterized by intense academic pressure, high-stakes examinations, and strong familial expectations for achievement (Zhang et al., 2025). The "alienating academic temporality" described by Rosa (2013) may be particularly acute in this context, where students often experience stress not only as individuals but as representatives of family honor. The "Dramatic Field" program's emphasis on collective exploration and mutual support (communitas) may resonate with Confucian values of relational harmony and collective wellbeing, potentially enhancing its acceptability and effectiveness in this cultural context. However, the same cultural factors might also create unique barriers—for instance, students may initially feel uncomfortable with the program's emphasis on emotional

expression and physical contact, which can conflict with norms of emotional restraint. Future research should explore how the program's mechanisms and outcomes may vary across cultural contexts, and whether cultural adaptation of the protocol is needed for implementation in Western settings.

Limitations and future directions

It is critical to interpret these findings within the inherent limitations of an exploratory design. The absence of baseline data precludes causal inference, as we cannot rule out pre-existing differences between high and low engagers (Stice et al., 2009). The cross-sectional nature of the quantitative data means we can only report correlations at a single point in time.

The large effect sizes observed should be viewed cautiously, as they may be influenced by common method variance (all measures were self-report) or the proximity of measurement to the program's conclusion. The newly developed Program Engagement measure, while appropriate for this initial exploration, requires further validation in future research. Additionally, facilitator characteristics may have influenced participant experiences, and future studies should systematically examine such effects.

The self-selected sample from a single university also limits generalizability, and the single post-program assessment does not speak to the longevity of the observed associations.

Despite these limitations, the study provides a rich phenomenological foundation for future research. Future studies should employ pre-post designs with control groups to build on the hypotheses generated here, including randomized controlled trials with active control groups and longer follow-up periods. The qualitative model also offers testable mediators (e.g., psychological distancing, embodied externalization) that could be quantitatively examined in future research.

Conclusion

This exploratory mixed-methods study successfully delineated the core experiences and preliminary correlates of participation in the "Dramatic Field" program. The findings suggest that the program is a feasible, engaging, and subjectively meaningful activity for university students experiencing academic stress. The strong correlations between engagement and psychological outcomes, coupled with the rich qualitative model of the spect-actor shift, generate compelling hypotheses about the program's potential benefits and its mechanisms of action. While cautious interpretation is warranted due to the exploratory design, this work makes a significant contribution by providing a comprehensive foundational understanding of the program's phenomenology. It establishes the "Dramatic Field" as a promising and innovative paradigm worthy of further, more rigorous investigation. The thoughtful integration of performance theory (Schechner, 1985; Boal, 2000), ritual studies (Turner, 1969; Van Gennep, 1960), and embodied cognition (Shapiro, 2019), as explored here, represents a fertile avenue for developing novel, somatic, and agentic approaches to supporting student wellbeing in an increasingly pressurized academic world (American Psychological Association, 2020; Rosa, 2013). This study serves as a critical first step, providing a map and a compass for future research to navigate the promising terrain of the "Dramatic Field."

Data availability statement

Due to the sensitive nature of the mental health data collected and the small sample size (N = 60), the raw data are not publicly available. Supplementary Tables S1, S2 provide descriptive statistics and the covariance matrix. Further inquiries can be directed to the corresponding author.

Ethics statement

The studies involving humans were approved by the Guangzhou University Institutional Review Board, approval number GZHU-IRB-2025–176. The studies were conducted in accordance with the local legislation and institutional requirements. The participants provided their written informed consent to participate in this study.

Author contributions

YH: Investigation, Methodology, Validation, Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Resources, Visualization, Formal analysis, Funding acquisition, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Data curation.

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